

# Is 5

E. E. Cummings

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## IS FIVE

## FIVE BOOKS

by E. E. Cummings

1. The Enormous Room
2. Tulips and Chimneys
3. &
4. Xli Poems
5. Is Five ¶

by E. E. Cummings

is

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## FOREWORD

On the assumption that my technique is either complicated or original or both, the publishers have politely requested me to write an introduction to this book.

At least my theory of technique, if I have one, is very far from original; nor is it complicated. I can express it in fifteen words, by quoting The Eternal Question And Immortal Answer of burlesk, viz. "Would you hit a woman with a child?--No, I'd hit her with a brick." Like the burlesk comedian, I am abnormally fond of that precision which creates movement.

If a poet is anybody, he is somebody to whom things made matter very little--somebody who is obsessed by Making. Like all obsessions, the Making obsession has disadvantages; for instance, my only interest in making money would be to make it. Fortunately, however, I should prefer to make almost anything else, including locomotives and roses. It is with roses and locomotives (not to mention acrobats Spring electricity Coney Island the 4th of July the eyes of mice and Niagara Falls) that my "poems" are competing.

They are also competing with each other, with elephants, and with El Greco.

Ineluctable preoccupation with The Verb gives a poet one priceless advantage: whereas nonmakers must content themselves with the merely undeniable fact that two times two is four, he rejoices in a purely irresistible truth (to be found, in abbreviated costume, upon the title page of the present volume.)

E. E. Cummings.

A LIST OF WHERE  
THESE POEMS

have been published

\*

England France Italy  
Austria and  
America

\*

TITLE IS V

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ONE

I

FIVE AMERICANS

I. LIZ

with breathing as (faithfully) her lownecked  
dress a little topples and slightly expands

one square foot mired in silk wrinkling loth  
stocking begins queerly to do a few  
gestures to death,

the silent shoulders are both  
slowly with pinkish ponderous arms bedecked  
whose white thick wrists deliver promptly to  
a deep lap enormous mindless hands.  
and no one knows what (i am sure of this)  
her blunt unslander, what her big unkeen

"Business is rotten" the face yawning said

what her mouth thinks of

(if it were a kiss

distinct entirely melting sinuous lean . . .  
whereof this lady in some book had read

II. MAME

she puts down the handmirror. "Look at" arranging  
before me a mellifluous idiot grin  
(with what was nose upwrinkled into nothing  
earthly, while the slippery eyes drown  
in surging flesh). A thumblike index down-  
dragging yanks back skin "see" (i, seeing, ceased  
to breathe). The plump left fist opening  
"wisdom." Flicker of gold. "Yep. No gas. Flynn"

the words drizzle untidily from released  
cheeks "I'll tell duh woild; some noive all right.  
Aint much on looks but how dat baby ached."

and when i timidly hinted "novocaine?"  
the eyes outstart, curl, bloat, are newly baked

and swaggering cookies of indignant light

### III. GERT

joggle i think will do it although the glad  
monosyllable jounce possibly can tell  
better how the balloons move (as  
her ghost lurks, a Beau Brummel sticking in its three-  
cornered always moist mouth)--jazz,  
for whose twitching lips, between you and me  
almost succeeds while toddle rings the bell.  
But if her tall corpsecoloured body seat  
itself (with the uncouth habitual dull  
jerk at garters) there's no sharpest neat  
word for the thing.

Her voice?

gruesome: a trull  
leaps from the lungs "gimme uh swell fite  
like up ter yknow, Rektuz, Toysday nite;  
where uh guy gets gayn troze uh lobstersalad

### IV. MARJ

"life?

Listen" the feline she with radishred  
legs said (crossing them slowly)"I'm  
asleep. Yep. Youse is asleep kid  
and everybody is." And i hazarded  
"god" (blushing slightly)--"O damn  
ginks like dis Gawd" opening slowly slowly  
them--then carefully the rolypoly  
voice squatting on a mountain of gum did  
something like a whisper, "even her."  
"The Madam?" I emitted; vaguely watching  
that mountainous worthy in the fragile act  
of doing her eyebrows.--Marj's laughter smacked  
me: pummeling the curtains, drooped to a purr . . .

i left her permanently smiling

### V. FRAN

should i entirely ask of god why  
on the alert neck of this brittle whore  
delicately wobbles an improbably distinct face,  
and how these wooden big two feet conclude  
happeningly the unfirm drooping bloated  
calves

i would receive the answer more  
or less deserved, Young fellow go in peace.  
which i do, being as Dick Mid once noted  
lifting a Green River (here's to youse)  
"a bloke wot's well behaved" . . . and always try  
to not wonder how let's say elation  
causes the bent eyes thickly to protrude--

or why her tiniest whispered invitation  
is like a clock striking in a dark house

### II

### POEM, OR BEAUTY HURTS MR. VINAL

take it from me kiddo  
believe me  
my country, 'tis of

you, land of the Cluett  
Shirt Boston Garter and Spearmint  
Girl With The Wrigley Eyes(of you  
land of the Arrow Ide  
and Earl &  
Wilson  
Collars)of you i  
sing:land of Abraham Lincoln and Lydia E. Pinkham,  
land above all of Just Add Hot Water And Serve--  
from every B. V. D.

let freedom ring

amen. i do however protest, anent the un  
-spontaneous and otherwise scented merde which  
greet one (Everywhere Why) as divine poesy per  
that and this radically defunct periodical. i would  
suggest that certain ideas gestures  
rhymes, like Gillette Razor Blades  
having been used and reused  
to the mystical moment of dullness emphatically are  
Not To Be Resharpened. (Case in point  
if we are to believe these gently O sweetly  
melancholy trillers amid the thrillers  
these crepuscular violinists among my and your  
skyscrapers--Helen&Cleopatra were Just Too Lovely,  
The Snail's On The Thorn enter Morn and God's  
In His andsoforth  
do you get me? (according  
to such supposedly indigenous  
throstles Art is O World O Life  
a formula:example, Turn Your Shirttails Into  
Drawers and If It Isn't An Eastman It Isn't A  
Kodak therefore my friends let  
us now sing each and all fortissimo A-  
mer  
i

ca, I  
love,  
You. And there're a  
hun-dred-mil-lion-oth-ers, like  
all of you successfully if  
delicately gelded(or spaded)  
gentlemen(and ladies)--pretty  
littliverpill-  
hearted-Nujolneeding-There's-A-Reason  
americans(who tensetendoned and with  
upward vacant eyes, painfully  
perpetually crouched, quivering, upon the  
sternly allotted sandpile  
--how silently  
emit a tiny violetflavoured nuisance:Odor?  
ono.  
comes out like a ribbon lies flat on the brush

III

curtains part)  
the peacockappareled  
prodigy of Flo's midnight

Frolic dolores

small in the head keen chassised like a Rolls

Royce

swoops smoothly

outward(amid

tinkling-cheering-hammering

tables)

while softly along Kirkland Street

the infantile ghost of Professor

Royce rolls

remembering that it

has for

-gotten some-

thing ah

(my

necktie

IV

workingman with hand so hairy-sturdy

you may turn O turn that airy hurdysturdygurdy

but when will turn backward O backward Time in your no thy flight

and make me a child, a pretty dribbling child, a little child.

In thy your ear:

en amerique on ne boit que de Jingyale.

things are going rather kaka

over there, over there.

yet we scarcely fare much better--

what's become of (if you please)

all the glory that or which was Greece

all the grandja

that was dada?

make me a child, stout hurdysturdygurdyman

waiter, make me a child. So this is Paris.

i will sit in the corner and drink thinks and think drinks,

in memory of the Grand and Old days:

of Amy Sandburg

of Algernon Carl Swinburned.

Waiter a drink waiter two or three drinks

what's become of Mæterlink

now that April's here?

(ask the man who owns one

ask Dad, He knows).

V

yonder deadfromtheneckup graduate of a

somewhat obscure to be sure university spends

her time looking picturesque under

the as it happens quite

erroneous impression that he

nascitur

VI

Jimmie's got a goil

goil

goil,

Jimmie

's got a goil and  
she coitnly can shimie  
when you see her shake  
shake  
shake,  
when  
you see her shake a  
shimie how you wish that you was Jimmie.

Oh for such a gurl  
gurl  
gurl,  
oh  
for such a gurl to  
be a fellow's twistandtwirl  
talk about your Sal-  
Sal-  
Sal-  
talk  
about your Salo  
-mes but gimmie Jimmie's gal.

## VII

the waddling  
madam star  
taps  
taps. "ready girls". the  
unspontaneous streets  
make bright their eyes  
a  
blind irisher fiddles a  
scotch jig in a stinking  
joyman bar  
a cockney is  
buying whiskies for a turk  
a waiter intones:bloo-moo-n  
sirkusricky  
platzburg  
hoppytoad yesmam. the  
furious taximan  
p(ee)ps  
on his whistle somebody  
says here's luck  
somebody else says down the hatch  
the nigger smiles  
the jew stands  
besides his teddy-bears  
the sailor shuffles the  
night with Φυκινυ eyes  
the great black preacher gargles jesu  
the aesthete indulges  
his soul for certain things which died  
it is eighteen hundred  
years. . . .  
exactly  
under the window  
under the window

under the window walk  
the unburied feet of  
the little ladies more than dead

## VIII

listen my children and you  
shall hear the true

story of Mr Do  
-nothing the wellknown parvenu  
who

(having dreamed of a corkscrew)  
studied with Freud a year or two  
and when Freud got through  
with Do-

nothing Do  
-nothing could do  
nothing which you  
and i are accustomed to  
accomplish two

or three times, and even a few  
more depending on the remu-  
nerativeness of the stimulus(eheu  
fu  
-gaces Postu-  
me boo

who)

## IX

even if all desires things moments be  
murdered known photographed,ourselves yawning will ask ourselves  
ou sont les neiges. . . . some

guys talks big

about Lundun Burlin an gay Paree an  
some guys claims der never was  
nutn like Nooer Leans Shikahgo Sain  
Loeey Noo York an San Fran dictaphones  
wireless subways vacuum  
cleaners pianolas funnygraphs skyscrapers an safetyrazors  
sall right in its way kiddo  
but as fer i gimme de good ole daze. . . .

in dem daze kid Christmas  
meant sumpn youse knows wot  
i refers ter Satter Naillyuh(comes but once er  
year)i'll tell de woild one swell bangup  
time wen nobody wore no cloze  
an went runnin aroun wid eachudder Hell  
Bent fer election makin believe dey was chust born

## X

death is more than  
certain a hundred these  
sounds crowds odours it  
is in a hurry  
beyond that any this  
taxi smile or angle we do  
not sell and buy

things so necessary as  
is death and unlike shirts  
neckties trousers  
we cannot wear it out  
  
no sir which is why  
granted who discovered  
America ether the movies  
may claim general importance  
  
to me to you nothing is  
what particularly  
matters hence in a  
  
little sunlight and less  
moonlight ourselves against the worms

hate laugh shimmy

XI

nobody loses all the time

i had an uncle named  
Sol who was a born failure and  
nearly everybody said he should have gone  
into vaudeville perhaps because my Uncle Sol could  
sing McCann He Was A Diver on Xmas Eve like Hell Itself which  
may or may not account for the fact that my Uncle

Sol indulged in that possibly most inexcusable  
of all to use a highfalootin phrase  
luxuries that is or to  
wit farming and be  
it needlessly  
added

my Uncle Sol's farm  
failed because the chickens  
ate the vegetables so  
my Uncle Sol had a  
chicken farm till the  
skunks ate the chickens when

my Uncle Sol  
had a skunk farm but  
the skunks caught cold and  
died and so  
my Uncle Sol imitated the  
skunks in a subtle manner

or by drowning himself in the watertank  
but somebody who'd given my Uncle Sol a Victor  
Victrola and records while he lived presented to  
him upon the auspicious occasion of his decease a  
scrumptious not to mention splendiferous funeral with  
tall boys in black gloves and flowers and everything and

i remember we all cried like the Missouri  
when my Uncle Sol's coffin lurched because  
somebody pressed a button  
(and down went  
my Uncle  
Sol

and started a worm farm)

XII

now dis "daughter" uv eve(who aint precisely slim )sim  
ply don't know duh meanin uv duh woid sin in  
not disagreeable contras tuh dat not exacly fat  
"father"(adjustin his robe)who now puts on his flat hat

### XIII

(and i imagine  
never mind Joe agreeably cheerfully remarked when  
surrounded by fat stupid animals  
the jewess shrieked  
the messiah tumbled successfully into the world  
the animals continued eating. And i imagine she, and  
heard them slobber and  
in the darkness)

stood sharp angels with faces like Jim Europe

### XIV

it really must  
be Nice, never to  
have no imagination)or never  
never to wonder about guys you used to(and them  
slim hot queens with dam next to nothing  
on)tangoing  
(while a feller tries  
to hold down the fifty bucks per  
job with one foot and rock a  
cradle with the other)it Must be  
nice never to have no doubts about why you  
put the ring  
on(and watching her  
face grow old and tired to which  
you're married and hands get red washing  
things and dishes)and to never, never really wonder i  
mean about the smell  
of babies and how you  
know the dam rent's going to and everything and never, never  
Never to stand at no window  
because i can't sleep(smoking sawdust  
cigarettes in the  
middle of the night

### XV

#### ITEM

this man is o so  
Waiter  
this;woman is  
please shut that  
the pout And affectionate leer  
interminable pyramidal,napkins  
(this man is oh so tired of this  
a door opens by itself  
woman.) they so to speak were in  
Love once?  
now  
her mouth opens too far  
and:she attacks her Lobster without

feet mingle under the  
mercy.  
(exit the hors d'œuvres)

XVI

it started when Bill's chip let on to  
the bulls he'd bumped a bloke back in fifteen.  
Then she came toward him on her knees across the locked  
room. he knocked her cold and beat it for Chicago.

Eddie was waiting for him, and they cleaned up a few  
times--before she got the info  
from a broad that knew Eddie in Topeka, went clean  
daffy, and which was very silly hocked

the diamond he gave her. Bill was put wise  
that she was coming with his kid inside her.  
He laughed. She came. he gave her a shove  
and asked Eddie did he care to ride her?  
. . . .she exactly lay, looking hunks of love

in The Chair he kept talking about eyes

XVII

IKEY(GOLDBERG)'S WORTH I'M  
TOLD \$ SEVERAL MILLION  
FINKLESTEIN(FRITZ)LIVES  
AT THE RITZ WEAR  
earl & wilson COLLARS

XVIII

?

why are these pipples taking their hets off?  
the king & queen  
alighting from their limousine  
inhabit the Hotel Meurice (whereas  
i live in a garret and eat aspirine)  
  
but who is this pale softish almost round  
young man to whom headwaiters bow so?  
hush--the author of Women By Night whose latest Seeds  
Of Evil sold 69 carloads before  
publication the girl who goes wrong you  
  
know(whereas when i lie down i cough too  
much). How did the traffic get so jammed?  
bedad it is the famous doctor who inserts  
monkeyglands in millionaires a cute idea n'est-ce pas?  
(whereas, upon the other hand, myself)but let us next demand  
  
wherefore yon mob  
an accident? somebody got concus-  
sion of the brain?--Not  
a bit of it, my dears merely the prime  
minister of Siam in native  
  
costume, who  
emerging from a pissoir  
enters abruptly Notre Dame(whereas  
de gustibus non disputandum est  
my lady is tired of That sort of thing

XIX

this young question mark man

question mark  
who suffers from  
indigestion question  
mark is a remarkably  
charming person

personally they tell

me as for me  
i only knows that  
as far as  
his pictures goes

he's a wet dream

by Cézanne

XX

mr youse needn't be so spry  
concernin questions arty  
each has his tastes but as for i  
i likes a certain party  
gimme the he-man's solid bliss  
for youse ideas i'll match youse  
a pretty girl who naked is  
is worth a million statues

XXI

i was sitting in mcsorley's. outside it was New York and beautifully snowing.

Inside snug and evil. the slobbering walls filthily push witless creases of screaming warmth chuck pillows are noise  
funnilly swallows swallowing revolv- ingly pompous a the swallowed mottle with smooth or a but of rapidly goes gobs  
the and of flecks of and a chatter sobbings intersect with which distinct disks of graceful oath, upsoarings the break on  
ceiling- flatness

the Bar.tinking luscious jigs dint of ripe silver with warmlyish wetflat splurging smells waltz the glush of squirting taps  
plus slush of foam knocked off and a faint piddle-of-drops she says I ploc spittle what the lands thaz me kid in no sir  
hopping sawdust you kiddo he's a palping wreaths of badly Yep cigars who jim him why gluey grins topple together  
eyes pout gestures stickily point made glints squinting who's a wink bum-nothing and money fuzzily mouths take big  
wobbly foot-steps every goggle cent of it get out ears dribbles soft right old feller belch the chap hic sum- more eh  
chuckles skulch. . . .

and i was sitting in the din thinking drinking the ale, which never lets you grow old blinking at the low ceiling my being  
pleasantly was punctuated by the al- ways retchings of a worthless lamp.

when With a minute terrif iceffortone dirty squeal of soiling light yanKing from bushy obscurity a bald greenish foetal  
head established It suddenly upon the huge neck around whose unwashed sonorous muscle the filth of a collar hung  
gently.

(spattered)by this instant of semiluminous nausea A vast wordless nondescript genie of trunk trickled firm- ly in to one  
exactly-mutilated ghost of a chair,

a;domeshaped interval of complete plasticity,shoul- ders,sprouted the extraordinary arms through an an- gle of  
ridiculous velocity commenting upon an un- clean table.and,whose distended immense Both paws slowly loved a dinted  
mug

gone Darkness it was so near to me, i ask of shad- ow won't you have a drink?

(the eternal perpetual question)

Inside snugandevil. i was sitting in mcsorley's It,did not answer.

outside.(it was New York and beautifully,snowing. . . .

XXII

she being Brand

-new;and you

know consequently a  
little stiff i was  
careful of her and(having  
thoroughly oiled the universal  
joint tested my gas felt of  
her radiator made sure her springs were O.

K.)i went right to it flooded-the-carburetor cranked her

up,slipped the  
clutch(and then somehow got into reverse she  
kicked what  
the hell)next  
minute i was back in neutral tried and

again slo-wly;bare,ly nudg. ing(my

lev-er Right-  
oh and her gears being in  
A 1 shape passed  
from low through  
second-in-to-high like  
greasedlightning justas we turned the corner ofDivinity

avenue i touched the accelerator and give

her the juice,good

(it

was the first ride and believe i we was  
happy to see how nice she acted right up to  
the last minute coming back down by the Public  
Gardens i slammed on  
the

internalexpanding  
&  
externalcontracting  
brakes Bothatonce and  
brought allofher tremB  
-ling  
to a:dead.

stand-  
;Still)

XXIII

slightly before the middle of Congressman Pudd  
's 4th of July oration, with a curse and a frown  
Amy Lowell got up  
and all the little schoolchildren sat down

XXIV

Dick Mid's large bluish face without eyebrows

sits in the kitchen nights and chews a two-bit  
cigar

waiting for the bulls to pull his joint.

Jimmie was a dude. Dark hair and nice hands.

with a little eye that rolled and made its point

Jimmie's sister worked for Dick. And had some rows  
over percent. The gang got shot up twice, it  
operated in the hundred ands

All the chips would kid Jimmie to give them a kiss

but Jimmie lived regular. stewed three times a week.  
and slept twice a week with a big toothless girl  
in Yonkers.

Dick Mid's green large three teeth leak  
smoke:remembering, two pink big lips curl. . . .  
how Jimmie was framed and got his

XXV

oDE

o  
the sweet & aged people  
who rule this world(and me and  
you if we're not very  
careful)

O,  
the darling benevolent mindless  
He--and She--  
shaped waxworks filled  
with dead ideas(the oh  
quintillions of incredible  
dodderingly godly toothless  
always-so-much-interested-  
in-everybody-else's-business

bipeds)OH  
the bothering  
dear unnecessary hairless

o  
ld

XXVI

on the Madam's best april the  
twenty nellie  
anyway and  
it's flutters everything  
queer;does smells he smiles is  
like Out of doors he's a with  
eyes and making twice the a week  
you kind of, know(kind well of  
A sort of the way he smile but  
and her a I mean me a  
Irish,cook but well oh don't  
you makes burst want to dear somehow  
quickyeyes when(now,dark dear oh)  
the iceman  
how,luminously  
oh how listens and,expands  
my somewherealloverme heart my  
the halfgloom coolish  
of The what are  
parks for wiggle yes has  
are leap,which,anyway  
give rapid lapfulls of  
idiotic big hands

XXVII

(as that named Fred  
-someBody:hippopotamus, scratch-

ing,one,knee with,its,  
friend observes I

pass Mr Tom Larsen twirls among

pale lips the extinct  
cigar)at

which

this(once flinger  
of lariats lean exroper of  
horned suddenly crashing things)man spits

quickly into the very bright spittoon

XXVIII

my uncle  
Daniel fought in the civil  
war band and can play the triangle  
like the devil)my

uncle Frank has done nothing for many  
years but fly kites and  
when the  
string breaks(or something)my uncle Frank breaks into  
tears. my uncle Tom

knits and is a kewpie above the ears(but

my uncle Ed  
that's  
dead from the neck

up is lead all over  
Brattle Street by a castrated pup

XXIX

than(by yon sunset's wintry glow  
revealed)this tall strong stalwart youth,  
what sight shall human optics know  
more quite ennobling forsooth?

One wondrous fine sonofabitch  
(to all purposes and intents)  
in which distinct and rich  
portrait should be included,gents

these(by the fire's ruddy glow  
united)not less than sixteen  
children and of course you know  
their mother,of his heart the queen

--incalculable bliss!

Picture it gents:our hero,Dan  
who as you've guessed already is  
the poorbuthonest workingman

(by that bright flame whose myriad tints  
enrich a visage simple,terse,  
seated like any king or prince  
upon his uncorrupted arse

with all his hearty soul aglow)  
his nightly supper sups  
it isn't snowing snow you know  
it's snowing buttercups

XXX

weazened Irrefutable unastonished  
two, countenances seated in arranging; sunlight  
with-ered unspea-king: tWeNtY, f i n g e r s, large  
four gnarled lips totter

Therefore, approaching my twentysix selves  
bulging in immortal Spring express a cry of  
How do you find the sun, ladies?

(gradually very gradually "there is not enough  
of it" their, hands  
minutely

answered

XXXI

MEMORABILIA

stop look &

listen Venezia: incline thine  
ear you glassworks  
of Murano;  
pause  
elevator nel  
mezzo del cammin' that means half-  
way up the Campanile, believe

thou me cocodrillo--

mine eyes have seen  
the glory of  
the coming of  
the Americans particularly the  
brand of marriageable nymph which is  
armed with large legs rancid  
voices Baedekers Mothers and kodaks  
--by night upon the Riva Schiavoni or in  
the felicitous vicinity of the de l'Europe  
Grand and Royal  
Danielli their numbers

are like unto the stars of Heaven. . . .

i do signore  
affirm that all gondola signore  
day below me gondola signore gondola  
and above me pass loudly and gondola  
rapidly denizens of Omaha Altoona or what  
not enthusiastic cohorts from Duluth God only,  
gondola knows Cincingondolanati i gondola don't

--the substantial dollarbringing virgins

"from the Loggia where  
are we angels by O yes  
beautiful we now pass through the look  
girls in the style of that's the  
foliage what is it didn't Ruskin  
says about you got the haven't Marjorie  
isn't this wellcurb simply darling"  
--O Education: O

thos cook & son

(O to be a metope  
now that triglyph's here)

### XXXII

a man who had fallen among thieves  
lay by the roadside on his back  
dressed in fifteenth rate ideas  
wearing a round jeer for a hat  
fate per a somewhat more than less  
emancipated evening  
had in return for consciousness  
endowed him with a changeless grin  
where a dozen staunch and leal  
citizens did graze at pause  
then fired by hypercivic zeal  
sought newer pastures or because  
swaddled with a frozen brook  
of pinkest vomit out of eyes  
which noticed nobody he looked  
as if he did not care to rise  
one hand did nothing on the vest  
its wideflung friend clenched weakly dirt  
while the mute trouserfly confessed  
a button solemnly inert.  
Brushing from whom the stiffened puke  
i put him all into my arms  
and staggered banged with terror through  
a million billion trillion stars

### XXXIII

Babylon slim  
-ness of  
evenslicing  
eyes are chisels  
scarlet Goes  
with her  
whitehot  
face, gashed  
by hair's blue cold  
jolts of  
lovecrazed abrupt  
flesh split "Pretty  
Baby"  
to  
numb rhythm before christ

### XXXIV

this evangelist  
buttons with his big gollywog voice  
the kingdom of heaven up behind and crazily  
skating thither and hither in filthy sawdust  
chucks and rolls  
against the tent his thick joggling fists  
he is persuasive  
the editor cigarstinking hobgoblin swims  
upward in his swivel chair one fist dangling scandal while  
rapidly through mist a defunct king as  
linotypes gobblehobble

our lightheavy twic twoc ingly attacks  
landing a onetwo  
which doubles up suddenly his bunged hinging  
victim against the  
giving ropes amid  
screams of deeply bulging thousands

i too omit one kelly

in response to howjedooze the candidate's new silk  
lid bounds gently from his baldness  
a smile masturbates softly in the vacant  
lot of his physiognomy  
his scientifically pressed trousers ejaculate spats

a strikingly succulent getup

but  
we knew a muffhunter and he said to us Kid.  
daze nutn like it.

XXXV

(ponder,darling,these busted statues  
of yon motheaten forum be aware  
notice what hath remained  
--the stone cringes  
clinging to the stone,how obsolete  
lips utter their extant smile. . . .  
remark

a few deleted of texture  
or meaning monuments and dolls  
resist Them Greediest Paws of careful  
time all of which is extremely  
unimportant)whereas Life

matters if or

when the your- and my-  
idle vertical worthless  
self unite in a peculiarly  
momentary

partnership(to instigate  
constructive

Horizontal

business. . . .even so,let us make haste  
--consider well this ruined aqueduct

lady,  
which used to lead something into somewhere)

XXXVI

ta

ppin

g

toe

hip

popot

amus Back

gen

teel-ly

lugu-

bri ous

eyes  
LOOPTHELOOP

as

fathandsbangrag

XXXVII

poets yeggs and thirsties

since we are spanked and put to sleep by dolls let  
us not be continually astonished should  
from their actions and speeches  
sawdust perpetually leak

rather is it between such beddings and  
bumpings of ourselves to be observed  
how in this fundamental respect the well  
recognised regime of childhood is reversed

meantime in dreams let us investigate  
thoroughly each one his optima rerum first  
having taken care to lie upon our  
abdomens for greater privacy and lest

punished bottoms interrupt philosophy

XXXVIII

Will i ever forget that precarious moment?

As i was standing on the third rail waiting for the next train to grind me into lifeless atoms various ab- surd thoughts  
slyly crept into my highly sexed mind.

It seemed to me that i had first of all really made quite a mistake in being at all born, seeing that i was wifeless and  
only half awake, cursed with pimples, correctly dressed, cleanshaven above the nombril, and much to my astonishment  
much impressed by having once noticed ( as an infantile phenomenon ) George Washington almost incompletely  
surrounded by well- drawn icecakes beheld being too strong, in brief :an American, if you understand that i mean what  
i say i believe my most intimate friends would never have gathered.

A collarbutton which had always not nothurt me not much and in the same place.

Why according to tomorrow's paper the proletariat will not rise yesterday.

Inexpressible itchings to be photographed with Lord Rothermere playing with Lord Rothermere billiards very well by  
moonlight with Lord Rothermere.

A crocodile eats a native, who in revenge beats it insensible with a banana, establishing meanwhile a re- ligious cult  
based on consubstantial intangibility.

Personne ne m'aime et j'ai les mains froides.

His Royal Highness said "peek-a-boo" and thirty tame fleas left the prettily embroidered howdah im- mediately.

Thumbprints of an angel named Frederick found on a lightning-rod, Boston, Mass.

such were the not unhurried reflections to which my organ of imperception gave birth to which i should or- dinarily  
have objected to which, considering the back- ground, it is hardly surprising if anyone hardly should call exactly  
extraordinary. We refer, of course, to my position. A bachelor incapable of occupation, he had long suppressed the  
desire to suppress the suppressed desire of shall we say: Idleness, while meaning its opposite? Nothing could be  
clearer to all concerned than that i am not a policeman.

Meanwhile the tea regressed.

Kipling again H. G. Wells, and Anatole France shook hands again and yet again shook again hands again, the former  
coachman with a pipewrench of the again latter then opening a box of newly without exaggeration shot with some  
difficulty sardines. Mr. Wiggin took Wrs. Miggin's harm in is, extinguishing the spittoon by a candle furnished by  
courtesy of the management on Thursdays, opposite which a church stood perfectly upright but not piano item:a water-  
melon causes indigestion to William Cullen Longfel- low's small negro son, Henry Wordsworth Bryant.

By this time,however,the flight of crows had ceased. I withdrew my hands from the tennisracket. All was over. One  
brief convulsive octopus, and then our hero folded his umbrella.

It seemed too beautiful.

Let us perhaps excuse me if i repeat himself:these,or nearly these,were the not unpainful thoughts which occupied the subject of our attention;to speak even less objectively,i was horribly scared i would actually fall off the rail before the really train after all arrived. If i should have made this perfectly clear,it entirely would have been not my fault.

### XXXIX

voices to voices, lip to lip  
i swear (to noone everyone) constitutes  
undying; or whatever this and that petal confutes. . .  
to exist being a peculiar form of sleep  
  
what's beyond logic happens beneath will;  
nor can these moments be translated: i say  
that even after April  
by God there is no excuse for May  
  
--bring forth your flowers and machinery:sculpture and prose  
flowers guess and miss  
machinery is the more accurate, yes  
it delivers the goods, Heaven knows  
  
(yet are we mindful, though not as yet awake,  
of ourselves which shout and cling, being  
for a little while and which easily break  
in spite of the best overseeing)  
  
i mean that the blond absence of any program  
except last and always and first to live  
makes unimportant what i and you believe;  
not for philosophy does this rose give a damn. . .  
  
bring on your fireworks, which are a mixed  
splendor of piston and of pistil; very well  
provided an instant may be fixed  
so that it will not rub, like any other pastel.  
  
(While you and i have lips and voices which  
are for kissing and to sing with  
who cares if some oneeyed son of a bitch  
invents an instrument to measure Spring with?  
  
each dream nascitur,is not made. . .)  
why then to Hell with that :the other; this,  
since the thing perhaps is  
to eat flowers and not to be afraid.

### XL

life hurl my  
yes,crumbles hand(ful released conarefetti)ev eryflitter,inga. where  
mil(lions of aflickf)litter ing brightmillion ofS hurl;edindodg:ing  
whom areEyes shy-dodge is bright cruMbshandful,quick-hurl edinwho  
Is fluttercrumbs,fluttercrimbs are floatfallin,g;allwhere:  
a:crimbflitteringish is arefloatsis ingfallall!mil,shy milbrightlions  
my(hurl flicker handful  
in)dodging are shybrigHteyes is crum bs(alll)if,ey Es

### TWO

#### I

the season 'tis, my lovely lambs,  
of Sumner Volstead Christ and Co.  
the epoch of Mann's righteousness  
the age of dollars and no sense.  
Which being quite beyond dispute

as prove from Troy (N. Y.) to Cairo  
(Egypt) the luminous dithyrambs  
of large immaculate unmute  
antibolshevistic gents  
(each manufacturing word by word  
his own unrivalled brand of pyro  
-technic blurb anent the (hic)  
hero dead that gladly (sic)  
in far lands perished of unheard  
of maladies including flu)

my little darlings, let us now  
passionately remember how--  
braving the worst, of peril heedless,  
each braver than the other, each  
(a typewriter within his reach)  
upon his fearless derrière  
sturdily seated--Colonel Needless  
To Name and General You know who  
a string of pretty medals drew

(while messrs jack james john and jim  
in token of their country's love  
received my dears the order of  
The Artificial Arm and Limb)

--or, since bloodshed and kindred questions  
inhibit unprepared digestions,  
come:let us mildly contemplate  
beginning with his wellfilled pants  
earth's biggest grafter, nothing less;  
the Honorable Mr. (guess)  
who, breathing on the ear of fate,  
landed a seat in the legislat-  
ure whereas tommy so and so  
(an erring child of circumstance  
whom the bulls nabbed at 33rd)

pulled six months for selling snow

II

opening of the chambers close

quotes the microscopic pithicoid President  
in a new frock  
coat(scrambling all  
up over the tribune dances crazily  
& &)&  
chatters about Peacepeacepeace(to  
droppingly  
descend amid thunderous anthropoid applause)pronounced

by the way Pay the

extremely artistic nevertobeextinguished fla  
-me of the(very prettily indeed)arra-  
nged souvenir of the in spite of himself fa  
-mous soldier minus his na-  
me(so as not to hurt the perspective of the(hei  
-nous thought)otherwise immaculately tabulated vicinity)invei-  
gles a few mildly curious rai  
-ned on people(both male and female  
created He

then, And every beast of the field

### III

"next to of course god america i  
love you land of the pilgrims' and so forth oh  
say can you see by the dawn's early my  
country 'tis of centuries come and go  
and are no more what of it we should worry  
in every language even deafanddumb  
thy sons acclaim your glorious name by gorrry  
by jingo by gee by gosh by gum  
why talk of beauty what could be more beaut-  
iful than these heroic happy dead  
who rushed like lions to the roaring slaughter  
they did not stop to think they died instead  
then shall the voices of liberty be mute?"

He spoke. And drank rapidly a glass of water

### IV

it's jolly  
odd what pops into  
your jolly tete when the  
jolly shells begin dropping jolly fast you  
hear the rrrmp and  
then nearerandnearerandNEARER  
and before  
you can

!

& we're

NOT  
(oh--  
--i say  
that's jolly odd  
old thing, jolly  
odd, jolly  
jolly odd isn't  
it jolly odd.

### V

look at this)  
a 75 done  
this nobody would  
have believed  
would they no  
kidding this was my particular  
pal  
funny aint  
it we was  
buddies  
i used to  
know  
him lift the  
poor cuss  
tenderly this side up handle  
with care  
fragile  
and send him home  
to his old mother in

a new nice pine box

(collect

VI

first Jock he  
was kilt a handsome  
man and James and  
next let me  
see yes Will that was  
cleverest  
he was kilt and my youngest  
boy was kilt last with  
the big eyes i loved like you can't  
imagine Harry was o  
god kilt he was kilt everybody was kilt

they called them the kilties

VII

lis  
-ten  
you know what i mean when  
the first guy drops you know  
everybody feels sick or  
when they throw in a few gas  
and the oh baby shrapnel  
or my feet getting dim freezing or  
up to your you know what in water or  
with the bugs crawling right all up  
all everywhere over you all me everyone  
that's been there knows what  
i mean a god damned lot of  
people don't and never  
never  
will know,  
they don't want  
to  
no

VIII

come, gaze with me upon this dome  
of many coloured glass, and see  
his mother's pride, his father's joy,  
unto whom duty whispers low  
"thou must!" and who replies "I can!"  
--yon clean upstanding well dressed boy  
that with his peers full oft hath quaffed  
the wine of life and found it sweet--  
a tear within his stern blue eye,  
upon his firm white lips a smile,  
one thought alone: to do or die  
for God for country and for Yale  
above his blond determined head  
the sacred flag of truth unfurled,  
in the bright heyday of his youth  
the upper class American  
unsullied stands, before the world:  
with manly heart and conscience free,

upon the front steps of her home  
by the high minded pure young girl  
much kissed, by loving relatives  
well fed, and fully photographed  
the son of man goes forth to war  
with trumpets clap and syphilis

## IX

little ladies more  
than dead exactly dance  
in my head, precisely  
dance where danced la guerre.

Mimi a  
la voix fragile  
qui chatouille Des  
Italiens

the putain with the ivory throat  
Marie Louise Lallemand  
n'es-ce pas que je suis belle  
cheri? les anglais m'aiment  
tous, les americains  
aussi. . . "bon dos, bon cul de Paris" (Marie  
Vierge  
Priez  
Pour  
Nous)

with the  
long lips of  
Lucienne which dangle  
the old men and hot  
men se promenant  
doucement le soir(ladies  
accurately dead les anglais  
sont gentils et les americains  
aussi, ils payent bien les americains dance  
exactly in my brain voulez  
vous coucher avec  
moi? Non? pourquoi?

ladies skilfully  
dead precisely dance  
where has danced la  
guerre j'm'appelle  
Manon, cinq rue Henri Mounier  
voulez vous coucher avec moi?  
te ferai Mimi  
te ferai Minette,  
dead exactly dance  
si vous voulez  
chatouiller  
mon lezard ladies suddenly  
j'm'en fout de negres

(in the twilight of Paris  
Marie Louise with queenly  
legs cinq rue Henri  
Mounier a little love  
begs, Mimi with the body  
like une boite a joujoux, want nice sleep?

toutes les petites femmes exactes  
qui dansent toujours in my  
head dis-donc,Paris

ta gorge mysterieuse  
pourquoi se promene-t-elle, pourquoi  
eclate ta voix  
fragile couleur de pivoine?)  
with the

long lips of Lucienne which  
dangle the old men and hot men  
precisely dance in my head  
ladies carefully dead

X

16 heures  
l'Etoile

the communists have fine Eyes

some are young some old none  
look alike the flics rush  
batter the crowd sprawls collapses  
singing knocked down trampled the kicked by  
flics rush(the

Flics, tidiyum, are  
very tidiyum reassuringly similar,  
they all have very tidiyum  
mustaches, and very  
tidiyum chins, and just above  
their very tidiyum ears their  
very tidiyum necks begin)  
let us add

that there are 50(fifty)flics for every  
one(1)communist and  
all the flics are very organically  
arranged  
and their nucleus(composed  
of captains in freshly-creased  
-uniforms with only-just-  
shined buttons  
tidiyum  
before and behind)has a nucleolus:

the Prefect of Police

(a dapper derbied  
creature, swaggers daintily  
twiddling  
his tiny cane  
and, mazurkas about tweak-  
ing his wing collar pecking at his im-  
-peccable cravat directing being  
shooting his cuffs  
saluted everywhere saluting  
reviewing processions of minions  
tappingpeopleontheback

“allezcirculez”)

--my he's brave. . . .  
the  
communists pick

up themselves friends  
& their hats legs &  
arms brush dirt coats  
smile looking hands  
spit blood teeth  
the Communists have(very)fine eyes  
(which stroll hither and thither through the  
evening in bruised narrow questioning faces)

## XI

my sweet old etcetera  
aunt lucy during the recent  
war could and what  
is more did tell you just  
what everybody was fighting  
for,  
my sister  
isabel created hundreds  
(and  
hundreds)of socks not to  
mention shirts fleaproof earwarmers  
etcetera wristers etcetera, my  
mother hoped that  
i would die etcetera  
bravely of course my father used  
to become hoarse talking about how it was  
a privilege and if only he  
could meanwhile my  
self etcetera lay quietly  
in the deep mud et  
cetera  
(dreaming,  
et  
cetera, of  
Your smile  
eyes knees and of your Etcetera)

## THREE

### I

now that fierce few  
flowers(stealthily)  
in the alive west  
begin  
requiescat this six  
feet of Breton big good  
body, which terminated  
in fists hair wood  
erect cursing hatless who  
(bent by wind)slammed hard--  
over the tiller;clattered  
forward skidding in outrageous  
sabots language trickling  
pried his black  
mouth with fat jibing  
lips,

once upon a  
(that is  
over: and the sea heaving  
indolent colourless forgets)time  
Requiescat.  
carry  
carefully the blessed large silent him  
into nibbling final worms

## II

Among

these  
red pieces of  
day(against which and  
quite silently hills  
made of blueandgreen paper  
scorchbend ingthem  
-selves-U  
pcurv E,into:  
anguish(clim  
b)ing  
s-p-i-r-a-  
l  
and,disappear)  
Satanic and blasé

a black goat lookingly wanders

There is nothing left of the world but  
into this noth  
ing il trene per  
Roma si-gnori?  
jerk.  
ilyr,ushes

## III

it is winter a moon in the afternoon  
and warm air turning into January darkness up  
through which sprouting gently, the cathedral  
leans its dreamy spine against thick sunset

i perceive in front of our lady a ring of people  
a brittle swoon of centrifugally expecting  
faces clumsily which devours a man, three cats,  
five white mice, and a baboon.

O a monkey with a sharp face waddling carefully  
the length of this padded pole;a monkey attached  
by a chain securely to this always talking  
individual, mysterious witty hatless.

Cats which move smoothly from neck to neck of bottles,cats  
smoothly willowing out and in between bottles,who step smoothly  
and rapidly along this pole over five squirming  
mice; or leap through hoops of fire,creating smoothness.

People stare, the drunker applaud  
while twilight takes the sting out of the vermilion  
jacket of nodding hairy Jaqueline who is given a mouse  
to hold lovingly,

our lady what do you think of this? Do your proud fingers and  
your arms tremble remembering something fragile

and which had been presented unto you by a mystery?  
... the cathedral recedes into weather without answering

#### IV

impossibly

motivated by midnight  
the flyspecked abdominous female  
indubitably tellurian  
strolls

emitting minute grins

each an intaglio.

Nothing

has also carved upon her much

too white forehead a pair of  
eyes which mutter thickly(as one merely  
terrificulous American an instant doubts  
the authenticity

of these antiquities--relaxing  
hurries

elsewhere;to blow

incredible wampum

#### V

inthe,exquisite;

morning sure lyHer eye s exactly sit,ata little roundtable  
among otherlittle roundtables Her,eyes count slow(ly

obstre poroustimidi ties surElyfl) oat iNg,the

ofpieces of of sunligh to fa l l in gof throughof treesOf.

(Fields Elysian

the like,a)sLEEPing neck a breathing a ,lies  
(slo wlythe wom an pa)ris her  
flesh:wakes  
in little streets

while exactlygir lisHlegs;play;ing;nake;D  
and

chairs wait under the trees

Fields slowly Elysian in  
a firmcool-Ness taxis,s.QuirM

and, b etw ee nch air st ott er s thesillyold  
WomanSellingBalloonS

In theex qui site

morning,

her sureLyeye s sit-ex actly her sitat a surely!little,  
roundtable amongother;littleexactly round. tables,

Her

.eyes

#### VI

candles and

Here Comes a glass box  
which the exhumed  
hand of Saint Ignatz miraculously  
inhabits. (people tumble

down. people crumble to their  
knees. people  
begin crossing people)and  
hErE cOmEs a glass box:  
surrounded by priests  
moving in fifty colours  
, sensuously  
(the crowd  
howls faintly  
blubbering pointing  
see  
yes)  
It  
here  
comes  
A Glass  
Box and incense with  
and oh sunlight--  
the crash of the  
colours(of the oh  
silently  
striding)priests-and-  
slowly,al,ways;procession:and

Enters

this  
church.  
toward which The  
Expectant stutter(upon artificial limbs,  
with faces like defunct geraniums)

VII

Paris;this April sunset completely utters  
utters serenely silently a cathedral  
before whose upward lean magnificent face  
the streets turn young with rain,  
spiral acres of bloated rose  
coiled within cobalt miles of sky  
yield to and heed  
the mauve  
of twilight(who slenderly descends,  
daintily carrying in her eyes the dangerous first stars)  
people move love hurry in a gently  
arriving gloom and  
see!(the new moon  
fills abruptly with sudden silver  
these torn pockets of lame and begging colour)while  
there and here the lithe indolent prostitute  
Night,argues

with certain houses

VIII

will out of the kindness of their hearts a few philosophers tell me  
what am i doing on top of this hill at Calchidas, in the sunlight?  
down ever so far on the beach below me a little girl in white  
spins,tumbles;rolling in sand.  
across this water,crowding tints:browns and whites showing,the dotting

millions of windows of thousands of houses--Lisboa. Like the crackle  
of a typewriter,in the afternoon sky.

goats and sheep are driven by somebody along a curve of road which  
eats into a pink cliff back and up leaning out of yellowgreen water.

they are building a house down there by the sea,in the afternoon.

rapidly a reddish ant travels my fifth finger.

a bird chirps in a tree,somewhere nowhere

and a little girl in white is tumbling

in sand

Clouds over

me are like bridegrooms

Naked and luminous

(here the absurd I; life, to peer and wear clothes.

i am altogether foolish, i suddenly make a fist out of ten fingers

voices rise from down ever so far--

hush.

Sunlight,

there are old men behind me I tell

you;several,incredible,sleepy

IX

but observe;although

once is never the beginning of

enough, is it(i do not pretend

to know the reason any more than.)But look:up--

raising, hoisting, a little

perhaps that and this, deftly

propping on smallest hands

the slim hinging you

--because

it's five o'clock

and these(i notice)trees winterbrief surly old

gurgles a nonsense of sparrows, the cathedral

shudders blackening;

the sky is washed with tone

now for a moon

to squat in first darkness

--a little moon thinner than

memory

faint

-er

than all the whys

which lurk

between your naked shoulderblades.--Here

comes a stout fellow in a blouse

just outside this window, touching the glass

boxes one by one with his magic

stick(in which a willing

bulb of flame bubbles)

see

here and here they explode

silently into crocuses of brightness. (That is enough

of life, for you. I understand. Once

again. . . .)sliding

a little downward,embrace me with your body's suddenly

curving entire warm questions

X

sunlight was over  
our mouths fears hearts lungs arms hopes feet hands  
under us the unspeaking Mediterranean bluer  
than we had imagined  
a few cries drifting through  
high air  
a sail a fishing boat somebody an invisible spectator,  
maybe certain nobodies laughing faintly

playing moving far below us

perhaps one villa caught like pieces  
of a kite in the trees, here  
and here reflecting  
sunlight  
(everywhere sunlight keen complete  
silent

and everywhere you your kisses your flesh mind breathing  
beside under around myself)  
by and by

a fat colour reared itself against the sky and the sea

. . . finally your eyes knew  
me, we smiled to each other, releasing lay, watching  
(sprawling, in  
grass upon a  
cliff) what had been something  
else carefully slowly fatally turning into ourselves . . .

while in the very middle of fire all

the world becoming bright and little melted.

FOUR

I

the moon looked into my window  
it touched me with its small hands  
and with curling infantile  
fingers it understood my eyes cheeks mouth  
its hands(slipping)felt of my necktie wandered  
against my shirt and into my body the  
sharp things fingered tinily my heart life

the little hands withdrew, jerkily, themselves

quietly they began playing with a button  
the moon smiled she  
let go my vest and crept  
through the window  
she did not fall  
she went creeping along the air  
over houses  
roofs

And out of the east toward  
her a fragile light bent gatheringly

II

if being morticed with a dream  
myself speaks  
(whispering,

suggesting that our souls  
inhabit whatever is between them)  
knowing my lips hands the way i move  
my habits laughter  
i say  
you will perhaps pardon,  
possibly you will comprehend. and how  
this has arrived your mind may guess  
if at sunset  
it should, leaning against me, smile;  
or(between dawn and twilight)giving  
your eyes, present me also  
with the terror of shrines  
which noone has suspected(but  
wherein silently  
always  
are kneeling the various deaths  
which are your lover lady:together with what keen  
innumerable lives he has not lived.

### III

here's a little mouse)and  
what does he think about, i  
wonder as over this  
floor(quietly with  
bright eyes)drifts(nobody  
can tell because  
Nobody knows, or why  
jerks Here &, here,  
gr(oo)ving the room's Silence)this like  
a littlest  
poem a  
(with wee ears and see?  
tail frisks)  
(gonE)  
"mouse",  
We are not the same you and  
i, since here's a little he  
or is  
it It  
? (or was something we saw in the mirror)?  
therefore we'll kiss;for maybe  
what was Disappeared  
into ourselves  
who (look). ,startled

### IV

but if i should say  
goodmorning trouble adds  
up all sorts of quickly  
things on the slate of that  
nigger's  
face(but  
If i should say thankyouverymuch  
mr rosenbloom picks strawberries  
with beringed hands)but if

i Should say solong my  
tailor  
chuckles  
like a woman in a dream(but if i  
should say  
Now the all saucers  
but cups if begin to spoons dance every-  
should where say over the damned table and we  
hold lips Eyes everything  
hands you know what  
happens)but if i should,  
Say,

V

in spite of everything  
which breathes and moves, since Doom  
(with white longest hands  
neatening each crease)  
will smooth entirely our minds  
--before leaving my room  
i turn, and(stooping  
through the morning)kiss  
this pillow, dear  
where our heads lived and were.

VI

you are not going to, dear. You are not going to and  
i but that doesn't in the least matter. The big  
fear Who held us deeply in His fist is  
no longer, can you imagine it  
i can't which doesn't matter  
and what does is possibly this dear, that we may resume  
impact with the inutile collide  
once more with the imaginable,love,and eat sunlight(do  
you believe it? i begin to and that doesn't matter)which  
i suggest teach us a new terror always  
which shall brighten  
carefully these things we consider life.  
Dear i put my eyes into you but that doesn't matter  
further than of old  
because you fooled the doctors,i touch you with hopesand  
words and with so and so: we are together, we will  
kiss or smile or move. It's different too isn't it  
different dear from moving as we, you  
and i,used to move when i thought you were going to(but  
that doesn't matter)  
when you thought you were going to America.  
Then  
moving was a matter of not keeping still;we were  
two alert lice in the blond hair of nothing

VII

since feeling is first  
who pays any attention  
to the syntax of things  
will never wholly kiss you;  
wholly to be a fool

while Spring is in the world  
my blood approves,  
and kisses are a better fate  
than wisdom  
lady i swear by all flowers. Don't cry  
--the best gesture of my brain is less than  
your eyelids' flutter which says  
we are for each other: then  
laugh, leaning back in my arms  
for life's not a paragraph

And death i think is no parenthesis

## VIII

some ask praise of their fellows  
but i being otherwise  
made compose curves  
and yellows, angles or silences  
to a less erring end)  
myself is sculptor of  
your body's idiom:  
the musician of your wrists;  
the poet who is afraid  
only to mistranslate  
a rhythm in your hair,  
(your fingertips  
the way you move)  
the  
painter of your voice--  
beyond these elements  
remarkably nothing is. . . . therefore, lady  
am i content should any  
by me carven thing provoke  
your gesture possibly or

any painting(for its own  
reason)in your lips  
slenderly should create one least smile  
(shyly  
if a poem should lift to  
me the distinct country of your  
eyes, gifted with green twilight)

## IX

supposing i dreamed this)  
only imagine, when day has thrilled  
you are a house around which  
i am a wind--  
your walls will not reckon how  
strangely my life is curved  
since the best he can do  
is to peer through windows, unobserved  
--listen, for(out of all  
things)dream is noone's fool;  
if this wind who i am prowls  
carefully around this house of you  
love being such, or such,  
the normal corners of your heart

will never guess how much  
my wonderful jealousy is dark  
if light should flower:  
or laughing sparkle from  
the shut house(around and around  
which a poor wind will roam

X

you are like the snow only  
purer fleeter, like the rain  
only sweeter frailer you  
whom certain  
flowers resemble but trembling(cowards  
which fear  
to miss within your least gesture the hurting  
skill which lives)and since  
nothing lingers  
beyond a little instant,  
along with rhyme and with laughter  
O my lady  
(and every brittle marvelous breathing thing)

since i and you are on our ways to dust

of your fragility  
(but chiefly of your smile,  
most suddenly which is  
of love and death a marriage)you give me

courage  
so that against myself  
the sharp days slobber in vain:

Nor am i afraid that  
this, which we call autumn, cleverly  
dies and over the ripe world wanders with  
a near and careful  
smile in his mouth(making

everything suddenly old and with his awkward eyes  
pushing  
sleep under and thoroughly  
into all beautiful things)

winter, whom Spring shall kill

XI

because  
you go away i give roses who  
will advise even yourself, lady  
in the most certainly(of what we  
everywhere do not touch)deep  
things;

remembering ever so  
tinely these, your crisp  
eyes actually shall contain new faeries

(and if your slim lips are amused, no wisest

painter of fragile  
Marys will understand  
how smiling may be made as  
skilfully.) But carry  
also, with that indolent and with

this flower wholly whom you do  
not ever fear,  
    me in your heart  
softly;not all  
but the beginning  
of mySelf

## XII

you being in love  
will tell who softly asks in love,  
am i separated from your body smile brain hands merely  
to become the jumping puppets of a dream? oh i mean:  
entirely having in my careful how  
careful arms created this at length  
inexcusable, this inexplicable pleasure--you go from several  
persons:believe me that strangers arrive  
when i have kissed you into a memory  
slowly, oh seriously  
--that since and if you disappear  
solemnly  
myself  
ask "life, the question how do i drink dream smile  
and how do i prefer this face to another and  
why do i weep eat sleep--what does the whole intend"  
they wonder. ohandthey cry "to be,being,thatiamalive  
this absurd fraction in its lowest terms  
with everything cancelled  
but shadows  
--what does it all come down to? love? Love  
if you like and i like, for the reason that i  
hate people and lean out of this window is love,love  
and the reason that i laugh and breathe is oh love and the reason  
that i do not fall into this street is love."

## XIII

Nobody wears a yellow  
flower in his buttonhole  
he is altogether a queer fellow  
as young as he is old  
when autumn comes,  
who twiddles his white thumbs  
and frisks down the boulevards  
without his coat and hat  
--(and i wonder just why that  
should please him or i wonder what he does)  
and why(at the bottom of this trunk,  
under some dirty collars)only a  
moment  
(or  
was it perhaps a year)ago i found staring  
me in the face a dead yellow small rose

## XIV

it is so long since my heart has been with yours  
shut by our mingling arms through  
a darkness where new lights begin and

increase,  
since your mind has walked into  
my kiss as a stranger  
into the streets and colours of a town--  
that i have perhaps forgotten  
how, always(from  
these hurrying crudities  
of blood and flesh)Love  
coins His most gradual gesture,  
and whittles life to eternity  
--after which our separating selves become museums  
filled with skilfully stuffed memories

XV

i am a beggar always  
who begs in your mind  
(slightly smiling, patient, unspeaking  
with a sign on his  
breast  
BLIND)yes i  
am this person of whom somehow  
you are never wholly rid(and who  
does not ask for more than  
just enough dreams to  
live on)  
after all, kid  
you might as well  
toss him a few thoughts  
a little love preferably,  
anything which you can't  
pass off on other people: for  
instance a  
plugged promise--  
then he will maybe(hearing something  
fall into his hat)go wandering  
after it with fingers;till having  
found  
what was thrown away  
himself  
taptaptaps out of your brain, hopes, life  
to(carefully turning a  
corner)never bother you any more.

XVI

if within tonight's erect  
everywhere of black muscles feels  
a weightless slowness(deftly  
muting the world's texture with drifted  
gifts of featheriest slenderness and  
how gradually which descending are suddenly  
received)or by doomfull connivance  
accurately thither and hither myself  
struts unremembered(rememberingly  
with in both pockets curled hands moves)  
why then toward morning he is a ghost whom

assault these whispering fists of hail

(and a few windows awaken certain faces  
busily horribly blunder through new light  
hush we are made of the same thing as perhaps

nothing, he murmurs carefully lying down)

## XVII

how this uncouth enchanted  
person, arising from a  
restaurant, looks breathes or moves  
--climbing(past light after  
light)to turn, disappears

the very swift and  
invisibly living  
rhythm of your Heart possibly

will understand;  
or why(in

this most exquisite of cities)all  
of the long night a fragile imitation of  
(perhaps)myself carefully wanders  
streets dark and, deep

with rain. . . .

(he, slightly whom or  
cautiously this person

and this imitation resemble,  
descends into the earth with the year  
a cigarette between his ghost-lips

gradually)  
remembering badly, softly  
your  
kissed thrice suddenly smile

## XVIII

i go to this window

just as day dissolves  
when it is twilight(and  
looking up in fear

i see the new moon  
thinner than a hair)

making me feel  
how myself has been coarse and dull  
compared with you, silently who are  
and cling  
to my mind always

But now she sharpens and becomes crisper  
until i smile with knowing  
--and all about  
herself

the sprouting largest final air

plunges  
inward with hurled  
downward thousands of enormous dreams

## FIVE

### I

after all white horses are in bed  
will you walking beside me, my very lady,  
if scarcely the somewhat city  
wiggles in considerable twilight  
touch (now) with a suddenly unsaid  
gesture lightly my eyes?  
And send life out of me and the night  
absolutely into me. . . . a wise  
and puerile moving of your arm will  
do suddenly that  
will do  
more than heroes beautifully in shrill  
armour colliding on huge blue horses,  
and the poets looked at them, and made verses,  
through the sharp light cryingly as the knights flew.

## II

touching you i say (it being Spring  
and night) "let us go a very little beyond  
the last road--there's something to be found"  
and smiling you answer "everything  
turns into something else, and slips away. . . .  
(these leaves are Thingish with moondrool  
and i'm ever so very little afraid")  
i say  
"along this particular road the moon if you'll  
notice follows us like a big yellow dog. You  
don't believe? look back. (Along the sand  
behind us, a big yellow dog that's . . . . now it's red  
a big red dog that may be owned by who  
knows)  
only turn a little your. so. And  
there's the moon,there is something faithful and mad"

## III

along the brittle treacherous bright streets  
of memory comes my heart,singing like  
an idiot, whispering like a drunken man  
who(at a certain corner, suddenly)meets  
the tall policeman of my mind.  
awake  
being not asleep, elsewhere our dreams began  
which now are folded:but the year completes  
his life as a forgotten prisoner  
--"Ici?"--"Ah non, mon cheri; il fait trop froid"--  
they are gone:along these gardens moves a wind bringing  
rain and leaves, filling the air with fear  
and sweetness. . . .pauses. (Halfwhispering. . . .halfsinging  
stirs the always smiling chevaux de bois)  
when you were in Paris we met here

## IV

our touching hearts slenderly comprehend  
(clinging as fingers, loving one another  
gradually into hands) and bend  
into the huge disaster of the year:

like this most early single star which tugs  
weakly at twilight, caught in thickening fear  
our slightly fingering spirits starve and smother;  
until autumn abruptly wholly hugs  
our dying silent minds, which hand in hand  
at some window try to understand  
the  
(through pale miles of perishing air, haunted  
with huddling infinite wishless melancholy,  
suddenly looming) accurate undaunted

moon's bright third tumbling slowly

V

if i have made, my lady, intricate  
imperfect various things chiefly which wrong  
your eyes (frailer than most deep dreams are frail)  
songs less firm than your body's whitest song  
upon my mind--if i have failed to snare  
the glance too shy--if through my singing slips  
the very skillful strangeness of your smile  
the keen primeval silence of your hair  
--let the world say "his most wise music stole  
nothing from death"--  
you only will create  
(who are so perfectly alive) my shame:  
lady through whose profound and fragile lips  
the sweet small clumsy feet of April came

into the ragged meadow of my soul.

\* \* \* \* \*

Non-standard spelling retained.

In the original on Page 46, the poem "this evangelist" is missing a line from the third stanza. That stanza in other editions is:

the editor cigarstinking hobgoblin swims  
upward in hisswivelchair one fist dangling scandal while  
five other fingers snitch  
rapidly through mist a defunct king as

Also in the original on Page 55, the poem "life hurl my" was placed landscape on the page.